

What a thesis is for

Week 2, Lecture 1 · LangoBee to \$10K MRR

Summer 2026 · Operating a Solo Language App from Zero Revenue

What we'll cover

- What a thesis is and why every early-stage decision needs one
- Locked decisions vs re-revisable ones: why the distinction matters
- The THESIS.md discipline: writing commitments in text, not memory
- LangoBee's current thesis: premium library, stated precisely
- The drift signal: how the shorts direction emerged
- Changing your mind on purpose, not by default

Locked decisions and drift

The difference between a thesis and a plan

A plan is a sequence of actions. A thesis is a falsifiable claim about the world.

- A plan: "ship the shorts feed, grow to 1,000 users, raise a round."
- A thesis: "comprehensible-input learners will pay \$7.99/mo for a curated premium library of native-level content."

The thesis tells you what evidence would prove or disprove it. A plan does not.

Without a thesis, every new idea looks equally valid. With one, you have a filter.

What drift looks like in practice

Drift is not a decision. It is the slow substitution of one thesis for another without noticing.

LangoBee: the founding locked decision was premium-only, curated library. By June 2026:

- The weekly report language had shifted to "freemium shorts feed."
- The shorts surface had 13 real users and 1 share.
- The library had 17,440 texts, 24% ever-return, and \$0 from trials.

Neither direction has been tested. Drift produced two bets running in parallel with no criteria for either.

(June 2026 snapshot)

Why drift is expensive for a solo founder

A venture-backed team can run two product bets in parallel. A solo founder cannot.

Drift costs:

- Engineering time split between incompatible surfaces
- Positioning that is incoherent to new users
- Inability to declare an experiment failed, because the criteria were never written

The fix is not to pick faster. It is to write the thesis down before building.

The THESIS.md discipline

What belongs in THESIS.md

A thesis file is a living document with exactly three parts:

1. **The locked claim.** One sentence. Falsifiable. States the customer, the problem, and the willingness to pay.
2. **The win condition.** The metric and threshold that would confirm the thesis by the deadline.
3. **The kill threshold.** The metric and threshold that would falsify it. Not "if things go badly," but the specific number.

A thesis without a kill threshold is an opinion, not a commitment.

(Ries, 2009; Duke, 2022)

What "locked" means and what it does not

A locked decision is one you will not revisit before the time box expires.

Locked means:

- You will not reopen the question at next week's planning meeting.
- You will not "just try" an alternative approach while the experiment runs.
- You will not revise the kill threshold after the data comes in.

Locked does not mean permanent. It means "this question is settled until the time box expires."
After the box, you re-examine with evidence.

(Duke, 2022)

LangoBee's current locked thesis

The original thesis as it should be written:

"Spanish learners pursuing comprehensible-input methods will pay \$7.99/month for a curated premium-only library of native-level YouTube content with per-word difficulty scoring."

Win condition: 10 paying subscribers by August 2026 with a 14-day trial conversion rate above 15%.

Kill threshold: fewer than 5 trials started by July 15 despite 50 real signups, with 0 paying conversions.

Neither condition has been checked. No trials have ever started. (June 2026 snapshot)

Changing your mind on purpose

The difference between drift and a deliberate change

A deliberate thesis change has three parts:

1. A written record of the old thesis and why the evidence falsified it.
2. A written statement of the new thesis with its own win and kill conditions.
3. A decision date, with evidence cited.

Drift has none of these. Drift is the thesis changing because building was easier in a new direction.

The Lean Startup taxonomy of pivot types (Ries, 2011) only applies when the move is deliberate. A drift is not a pivot; it is a loss of position.

Why THESIS.md beats memory

Solo founders have no board meeting, no co-founder check-in, no investor forcing a pivot review. Without a written record, every week's build can silently move the thesis.

THESIS.md is version-controlled. It is queryable by a future session or agent. It is immune to motivated forgetting.

The discipline: every week, before the build block opens, the founder reads THESIS.md and asks: "Am I building for this thesis or against it?" If the answer is against it, the build stops and the thesis is revised deliberately.

Two theses, one THESIS.md

The correct next step is not to pick one immediately. It is to write both as separate falsifiable claims with separate win conditions and kill thresholds, and to set a decision date.

Curated premium library at \$7.99/mo drives paid conversion. Win: 10 paying users by Aug 15. Kill: 0 trials by Jul 15 from 50 real signups.

Freemium shorts feed drives retention and word-of-mouth. Win: 100 real users with 30% D7 retention by Aug 15. Kill: fewer than 50

As of June 2026, LangoBee has two competing directions. THESIS.md does not yet exist.

Thesis A (library)

Thesis B (shorts)

Successful startups keep one foot in validated learning while placing one foot toward a new hypothesis. Startups that simply jump to a completely different vision discard what they learned and start blind.
(Paraphrased)

Eric Ries (2009)

Pivot, Don't Jump to a New Vision

Take-aways

1. A thesis is a falsifiable claim about a customer, a problem, and willingness to pay, not a plan or a direction.
2. Drift is the thesis changing without a deliberate decision. It is expensive for a solo founder because it splits scarce build time between incompatible bets.
3. THESIS.md records the locked claim, the win condition, and the kill threshold in version-controlled text.
4. "Locked" means the question is settled until the time box expires, not permanently.
5. The next step for LangoBee is to write both competing directions as separate falsifiable theses before choosing.

What's next

- **Reading:** "Week 2: Thesis discipline and the fork decision" at </c/langobee-10k-mrr-26su/readings/wk02>
- **Lecture 2 (this week):** Pivot or persevere: Ries pivot taxonomy, time-boxed experiments, and the shorts feed as a zoom-in pivot candidate
- **Section this week:** Write the fork decision memo with explicit hypotheses, kill thresholds, and a decision date
- **HW1:** Still in flight, due week 3